

the starting boxes were flung open, and the chariots thundered out. At the Circus Maximus, up to 12 chariots raced at a time, driving counterclockwise around the track for seven laps. They covered 3.2 miles (5.2 km), reaching speeds of up to 46 mph (75 kph). Races probably lasted between 8 and 9 minutes.

WEIRD WORLD

CURSES, WRITTEN ON PIECES OF LEAD, WERE SOMETIMES BURIED OUTSIDE THE RACE TRACK BY PEOPLE WHO WANTED A PARTICULAR CHARIOTEER TO HAVE AN ACCIDENT SO THAT THEIR OWN FAVORITE WOULD WIN!

Dangers of the track

Charioteers needed all their skills not only to control their horses, but also to avoid crashing into the other chariots. But pile-ups did happen, especially at each end of the track, where there was a sharp turn. And it wasn't just the charioteers and their horses who risked their lives. Boys stood at the edge of the race track throwing water to refresh the horses and drivers—careless lads ended up under the chariot wheels.

The biggest race meetings at the Circus Maximus usually had 24 races a day, involving about 1,000 horses. In between races, acrobats kept the noisy crowd entertained, racing at full speed as they jumped from one horse to the next. At the end of a meeting, the winners received the same sort of prizes as victorious gladiators did—palm branches and lots of money.



THE FILM *BEN HUR* RECREATED A CHARIOT RACE AT THE CIRCUS MAXIMUS.